

The Sky Promises Many Big Events in 2025

The world will have to wait until 2026 for the next total solar eclipse. However, the sky promises plenty of other big events in 2025.

The new year starts off with a six-planet parade in January that people will be able to see for weeks. The smallest planet, Mercury, will join the crowd for a seven-planet line in February.

The Planetary Society's chief scientist Bruce Betts said about the visible planets, "People should go out and see them sometime during the next many weeks. I certainly will."

Here is a look ahead to the major sky events in 2025:

Eclipses

The moon will disappear for more than an hour over North and South America on March 14. The event will be followed two weeks later by a partial solar eclipse. People in Maine, eastern Canada, Greenland, Europe, Siberia and northwestern Africa will be able to watch the show.

In September, there will be an even longer total lunar eclipse over Europe, Asia, Africa and Australia. Two weeks later, a partial solar eclipse will take place in the area over the South Pacific, including New Zealand and parts of Antarctica.

Supermoons

Three supermoons are coming this year in October, November and December.

The full moon will look especially big and bright those three months as it orbits closer to Earth than usual.

November's supermoon will come closest, passing within 356,980 kilometers from Earth. Last year had four supermoons, ending in November.

Planet parade

This month, six of our seven neighboring planets will line up in the sky to form a long arc. All but Neptune and Uranus should be visible with the eye just after sunset, weather permitting.

The parade will continue for weeks. Mercury will make a short appearance by the end of February. The planets will slowly exit, one by one, through spring.

FILE - The northern lights appear over homes in Anchorage, Alaska, on Wednesday, Jan. 1, 2025. (AP Photo/Mark Thiessen)

Northern and southern lights

Geomagnetic storms painted the sky with beautiful colors in unexpected places last year.

Space weather experts predict more of these storms this year. Such storms could produce even more northern and southern lights.

The reasoning for the prediction is that the sun has reached its solar maximum during its current 11-year cycle. The cycle could continue through this year. The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's Shawn Dahl urges everyone to follow space weather news, so as not to miss any colorful shows.

Meteor showers

The Perseid and Geminid meteor events, or showers, are well-known crowd-pleasers. The Perseids will take place in August. The Geminids come in December. But do not forget about the smaller meteor showers including the Lyrids in April, the Orionids in October and the Leonids in November.

Areas away from cities, where night skies are darker, are best for watching the events. Generally, meteor showers are named for the constellation which they appear to come from. They take place whenever Earth moves through paths of debris left behind by comets and sometimes asteroids.

I'm John Russell.

Marcia Dunn reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

eclipse - n. คราส; การบังกันของวัตถุท้องฟ้าทั้งหมดหรือบางส่วน

supermoon - n. ซูเปอร์มูน; ปรากฏการณ์พระจันทร์เต็มดวงที่เกิดขึ้นเมื่อดวงจันทร์โคจรเข้าใกล้โลกมากที่สุดหรือเกือบที่สุดในวงโคจรของมัน

arc - n. ส่วนโค้ง; เส้นทางที่โค้งงอหรือเป็นรูปโค้งชนิดพิเศษ

maximum - n. ค่าสูงสุด; ขีดจำกัดบน; จุดที่สูงที่สุดหรือไกลที่สุด

cycle - n. วัฏจักร; ลำดับเหตุการณ์หรือการดำเนินงานที่เกิดขึ้นเป็นประจำ

constellation - n. กลุ่มดาว; กลุ่มของดาวฤกษ์ที่เห็นเป็นรูปร่างต่างๆ

debris - n. ซากปรักหักพัง; เศษซากของบางสิ่ง (มักใช้กับสิ่งที่ถูกทำลายหรือแตกหัก)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to the article, when is the next total solar eclipse anticipated?

- A. In the current year, 2025
- B. In two years, 2027
- C. In the upcoming year, 2026
- D. The article does not specify

2. What major astronomical event is expected to begin in January of the new year, lasting for several weeks?

- A. A total solar eclipse
- B. A six-planet parade
- C. A seven-planet alignment
- D. A supermoon

3. Which planet will join the 'planet parade' in February to complete a seven-planet line?

- A. Neptune
- B. Uranus
- C. Mercury
- D. Mars

4. What does Bruce Betts, chief scientist of The Planetary Society, advise people to do regarding the visible planets?

- A. To research them online
- B. To wait for special viewing events
- C. To go out and observe them soon
- D. To consult with an astronomer

5. On March 14th, which regions will experience a lunar eclipse lasting over an hour?

- A. Europe and Asia
- B. North and South America
- C. Africa and Australia
- D. Greenland and Siberia

6. Following the March 14th lunar eclipse, where will the subsequent partial solar eclipse be observable?

- A. Only in North America
- B. Primarily in Europe and Africa
- C. Across Maine, Eastern Canada, Greenland, Europe, Siberia, and Northwestern Africa

D. In the South Pacific region

7. In September, an 'even longer total lunar eclipse' is predicted to occur over which specific continents?

- A. North and South America
- B. Europe, Asia, Africa, and Australia
- C. Only Australia and New Zealand
- D. Greenland, Siberia, and Antarctica

8. The partial solar eclipse occurring two weeks after the September total lunar eclipse will be visible in which general area?

- A. Northern Europe
- B. The Atlantic Ocean
- C. The South Pacific, including New Zealand and parts of Antarctica
- D. Eastern Asia

9. How many supermoons are scheduled for the current year (2025) and in which months?

- A. Four, from September to December
- B. Three, in October, November, and December
- C. Two, in November and December
- D. Five, spread throughout the year

10. What is the primary characteristic that defines a full moon as a 'supermoon'?

- A. It occurs during an eclipse.
- B. It appears unusually big and bright due to its closer orbit to Earth.
- C. It is visible only from specific continents.
- D. It is accompanied by a meteor shower.

11. Which of the 2025 supermoons is predicted to pass closest to Earth, specifically within 356,980 kilometers?

- A. The October supermoon
- B. The November supermoon
- C. The December supermoon
- D. All three supermoons will be equally close

12. According to the article, how many supermoons occurred last year?

- A. Two
- B. Three

C. Four

D. Five

13. During the six-planet parade mentioned, which two planets are explicitly stated as **not being visible to the naked eye?**

A. Mars and Jupiter

B. Saturn and Venus

C. Neptune and Uranus

D. Mercury and Venus

14. When is Mercury expected to make a brief appearance during the continuing planet parade?

A. Early January

B. Mid-February

C. By the end of February

D. Throughout spring

15. What phenomenon, predicted to occur more frequently this year, is cited as a potential cause for an increase in northern and southern lights?

A. Meteor showers

B. Total solar eclipses

C. Geomagnetic storms

D. Supermoon events